

Networking Guide and Tip Sheet

Intern/ New Hire Networking Guide

Networking is one of the best ways to learn more about Impact Advisors, understand different service lines, career paths, and build relationships that can support your growth. The goal is not to “collect contacts,” but to have thoughtful conversations, learn from others’ experiences, and grow your career.

1. Why Networking Matters

Networking helps you:

- Learn what different teams and roles actually do day to day
- Understand our company’s culture, expectations, and career paths
- Build relationships with people outside your immediate team
- Get advice on how to succeed during your internship
- Explore potential areas of interest for future opportunities

A good networking conversation should feel professional, curious, and respectful.

2. How to Identify People to Reach Out To

Start with people who are relevant to your interests or internship experience, such as:

- Team members you work with directly
- Managers or senior leaders in your workstream/service line
- Employees in areas you want to learn more about
- People with interesting career paths or backgrounds
- Colleagues recommended by your manager, mentor, coach or buddy

It is okay to reach out to someone you have not met before, as long as your message is polite and specific.

3. How to Ask for a Coffee Chat

Keep your outreach short, professional, and flexible.

Example message:

Title: [Your Name]/[Their Name] Coffee Chat

“Hi [Name],

I hope you’re doing well. My name is [Your Name], and I’m currently an intern on the [Team Name] team. I’m interested in learning more about your role and career path in [Workstream name], and I was wondering if you would be open to a quick 30-minute coffee chat.

I’m happy to work around your schedule. Thank you in advance!

Best,

[Your Name]”

When possible, try to schedule coffee chats on **Fridays**, since many employees may be traveling or prioritizing client work Monday through Thursday. Fridays are often a better time for internal conversations, but always be flexible based on the person’s availability.

When reaching out to senior leaders, we recommend scheduling meetings directly based on their calendar availability and including your message in the body of the invite. This approach avoids the added back-and-forth of sending an initial email, waiting for a response, and then following up with a calendar hold.

Conversely, when connecting with more junior or mid-level professionals, it’s generally more appropriate to start with a brief email expressing your interest. You can then ask to meet at their convenience for a coffee chat or informal conversation before sending a calendar invite.

In all cases, be mindful and respectful of others’ time—paying close attention to scheduling preferences, availability, and time zones when networking or setting up meetings.

4. Come Prepared

Before the conversation, spend a few minutes preparing. This shows respect for the other person’s time.

You should:

- Look up their role, team, and background if available
- Understand the basics of what their team does
- Prepare 5–7 thoughtful questions
- Know what you want to learn from the conversation
- Be ready to briefly introduce yourself

A strong introduction can be simple:

“I’m currently interning with [Team], and I’ve been working on [brief project/context]. I’m hoping to learn more about your role, your experience at the company, and any advice you have for someone early in their career.”

5. Good Questions to Ask

Try to ask open-ended questions that invite the person to share their experiences.

Questions About Their Role

- Can you tell me more about your current role and what your day-to-day work looks like?
- What types of projects do you typically work on?
- What skills are most important for someone in your role?
- What do you enjoy most about your work?
- What are some of the biggest challenges your team is focused on right now?

Questions About Their Career Path

- How did you get to your current role?
- What experiences helped you grow the most early in your career?
- Was there anything that surprised you when you first joined the company?
- Looking back, what advice would you give yourself when you were starting out?

Questions About the Company

- How would you describe the company culture?

- What makes someone successful here?
- Are there any habits or behaviors you have seen in high-performing employees?
- What do you think interns should take advantage of while they are here?

Questions About Growth and Development

- What skills should I focus on developing during my internship?
- How can interns make a strong impression?
- Are there any resources, teams, or people you recommend I learn from?
- What advice do you have for someone interested in building a long-term career in this field?

6. Be Respectful of Their Time

Most employees are balancing client work, internal meetings, deadlines, and travel. Be thoughtful and professional.

Best practices:

- Ask for 30 minutes maximum, not an hour
- Show up on time
- Dress professionally
- Come prepared with questions
- Avoid asking questions you could easily answer yourself online
- Keep track of time during the conversation
- End on time unless they clearly offer to continue
- Be understanding if they need to reschedule or decline

A good way to close the meeting:

“I want to be respectful of your time, so I’ll pause here. Thank you so much for speaking with me — this was really helpful.”

7. What Not to Do

Avoid making the conversation feel transactional or unprepared.

Do not:

- Show up without knowing anything about the person
- Dominate the conversation
- Ask overly personal questions
- Schedule a meeting and then cancel last-minute without a good reason
- Go over time without asking
- Forget to wrap up the coffee chats with a genuine thank you note and your takeaway

The goal is to build a relationship, not to ask for something right away.

8. Optional: Follow Up After the Conversation

Send a thank-you message within 24 hours.

Example follow-up:

Hi [Name],

Thank you again for taking the time to speak with me today. I really enjoyed learning more about your role and your experience at [be specific]. I especially appreciated your advice on [specific topic].

Thanks again for your time, and I hope to stay in touch.

Including one specific takeaway makes the message more genuine.

9. How to Maintain the Relationship

Networking does not end after one conversation. You can stay in touch naturally over time.

Ways to maintain the relationship:

- Send a short update later in the internship
- Thank them again if their advice helped you
- Share a relevant article or project update

- Say hello at company events (Impact Palooza!)
- Ask for a follow-up conversation only when you have a clear reason

Keep it light and professional. You do not need to overdo it.

10. Key Takeaways

A successful networking conversation should be:

- **Prepared:** Know who you are speaking with and have thoughtful questions ready.
- **Respectful:** Be mindful of the other person's time and schedule.
- **Curious:** Focus on learning from their experience.
- **Professional:** Communicate clearly and follow up afterward.
- **Relationship-focused:** Build genuine connections rather than treating networking as a transaction.

Networking is a skill that improves with practice. The more intentional, thoughtful, and respectful you are, the more valuable these conversations will be.